Inquiry-Relative Categories: English Interjections as a Worked Case

Brett Reynolds *
Humber Polytechnic & University of Toronto

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Abstract

Linguistic category disputes often seek one classification for expressions that support several kinds of inference. I develop an account of inquiry-relative categories through English interjections. Established grammatical descriptions support a core including *ouch*, *oops*, *hey*, and *sh*: their conventional uses connect independent utterance with clausal supplementation and restricted integration. Grammatical membership also supports expectations about characteristic meanings and conversational uses, separate intonational packaging, and possibilities for unusual phonology. These associations make the category informative across inquiries without making the classifications interchangeable. Expressive contribution, for example, connects standalone *Damn!* with prenominal *damn* across a grammatical difference. Comparing stance with sound depiction in *Bang!* shows why even one semantic inquiry can require several distinctions. These cases show how crosscutting classifications can be mutually informative. A category's basis of identification doesn't confine the domain of its useful predictions, and a partial association doesn't erase the differences between groupings. Several classifications can be correct without one superseding the others, while incompatible claims about the same use remain open to empirical adjudication.

Keywords: inquiry-relative categories; category pluralism; projectibility; interjections; sign-types; path dependence

AI use. The large language models Claude Opus 4.8, Claude Opus 5, Claude Opus 5.5, GPT-5.6 Sol, GPT-6 Astra Pro, and GPT-6 (Codex) served as drafting and editing aids throughout the preparation of this paper. I am responsible for all theoretical claims, arguments, errors, and interpretive choices.

1 Introduction

Standalone *Damn!*, complement-taking *Damn these mosquitoes!*, and prenominal *damn* in *the damn car* present different combinations of grammatical and semantic properties. The modifier participates in a noun phrase while retaining an expressive contribution. The standalone form can constitute a stance display. The complement-taking expression has internal structure even when the whole

*Contact: brett.reynolds@humber.ca

expression stands apart from a surrounding clause. A single judgment about whether *damn* is an interjection leaves these differences unresolved.

A grammatical answer begins with a category whose members support expectations about their use in constructions. *Ouch!* can constitute an utterance and supplement a clause in *Ouch, that hurt*. Attention-getting *hey* and silencing *sh* share the broad grammatical profile despite their different conversational jobs. Their grammatical membership also supports expectations about meaning and realization: reactions, affective displays, and attempts to direct attention or action are characteristic, as is separate intonational packaging. A grammatical classification can thus guide inquiry beyond grammar.

A comparison with depictive *Bang!* exposes a further distinction. The selected *damn* use conveys an evaluative stance; the selected *Bang!* depicts a sound. Both concern meaning, but they motivate different groupings and different questions about interpretation. Grouping one under semantics and the other under semiotics would do nothing to resolve those questions. Nor would calling both interjections establish that they share the relevant semantic properties.

This paper asks what warrants recognizing a category for an inquiry. An inquiry identifies a question and a standard of success; evidence constrains which grouping answers it. A field can pursue several inquiries, an inquiry can employ several categories, and a category can serve questions pursued across fields. What establishes membership and what membership warrants expecting are distinct questions. English interjections make this many-to-many relation visible because grammatical, semantic, interactional, phonological, and historical descriptions repeatedly organize overlapping material.

A grouping can make measurement comparable or description informative. The distinctions among *damn* uses have descriptive value even before a new prediction is tested. Projectibility concerns the warrant for expectations beyond the evidence used to identify a case (Goodman, 1955). Neither descriptive usefulness nor a successful projection identifies its own causal explanation. These achievements need separate assessment.

Pluralism about useful and objectively grounded groupings has substantial precedents. Dupré (1993, pp. 5–7, 17–18) relates the choice of classification to the goals of inquiry while rejecting one uniquely privileged division of things. Khalidi (2013, pp. 63–64, 69–72) defends crosscutting kinds answering different epistemic interests. Their wider metaphysical commitments needn't all be adopted to recognize that distinct questions can require overlapping groupings.

Within linguistics, Haspelmath (2010, pp. 663, 666, 680) distinguishes language-particular descriptive categories from concepts designed for cross-language comparison. The division of labour here is different: several inquiries within English can organize the same expressions differently. The assessment developed here starts with a positive grammatical case and follows its relation to other groupings. The grammatical category supports a wider profile of expectations, including expressive and conative contributions. An expressive grouping connects uses across its grammatical boundary. Their partial alignment makes the classifications informative about one another while leaving each with work to do. Specifying the bearer, grouping, and intended inference also shows when two analyses compete and what evidence could decide between them.

The worked cases are named for the relations they investigate: grammatical interjections, expressive signs, depictive signs, continuers, repair initiators, and closing formats. They needn't all operate at the same level of generality or retain an interjection label. In these comparisons, the common bearer

is a conventionalized sign-type, an identifiable expression in a conventional use. Classifications of realizations or historical changes require explicit relations to these sign-types.

The historical case concerns PATH DEPENDENCE: development can leave source-specific traces after uses converge. Gehweiler's history of *gee* supplies a documented explanation of one outcome; a verbal route to complement-taking *damn* remains partly reconstructive. The corpus material has a narrower role, showing how tags and strings can fail to identify the intended bearers. A linked supplement preserves the detailed measurement checks and two withdrawn confirmatory analyses.

Section 2 establishes a grammatical core and its wider profile, traces expressive commonality across grammatical differences, and compares expressive and depictive contributions. Section 3 distinguishes the achievements of these groupings. Sections 4 and 5 apply the assessment to phonological and historical claims; Section 6 considers broader social and processing classes. The measurement case and discussion then draw out what changes when the object, grouping, and claim are kept explicit.

2 Several groupings of conventional signs

Grammars and studies of meaning and interaction organize the traditional interjection domain differently. Jespersen (1924, p. 90) treated interjection as a manner in which words of other categories are used. *The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language* (*CGEL*) recognizes a lexical category (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 22). The *Longman Grammar of Spoken and Written English* places interjections within the broader class of inserts, while assigning *damn*, *gosh*, and *gee* to expletives (Biber et al., 1999, pp. 1082–1083, 1094–1095).

The disputes concern a well-studied domain. Libert (2019) questions the description of interjections as neglected; Cram (2008, p. 63) identifies their recurring role in controversies over the syntax–pragmatics and semantics–pragmatics boundaries. The following comparisons preserve what those traditions distinguish without treating each tradition as the source of exactly one category.

2.1 A grammatical core and what it projects

Someone drops a cup and says *Oops!*; someone catches a finger in a drawer and says *Ouch!*. Either reaction can also accompany a clause. The following constructed pairs illustrate the two environments.

(1) a. *Oops!* *Oops, I've dropped it!*
b. *Ouch!* *Ouch, that hurt!*

In the independent utterances, the lexical item supplies the expression without an unspoken clause. In the longer examples, it functions as a supplement to the clause. *I've dropped it* and *that hurt* are already complete: the reaction fills no argument or integrated modifier position within them. These are two characteristic environments for the grammatical category INTERJECTION.

I take *ah*, *hey*, *oh*, *oops*, *ouch*, *sh*, *ugh*, and *wow*, in their conventional interjectional uses, as a working core. *CGEL* identifies these as central members and attributes both independent and supplementary use to them (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1361). Its additional example *alas* illustrates how a dated form can have a secure grammatical assignment. Here, CORE concerns the support for those assignments, rather than frequency or typicality.

The shared profile combines these positive possibilities with restricted integration. The selected uses are characteristically invariant and don't participate in the ordinary argument, predicative, and

modifier patterns of nouns, verbs, and adjectives. Ameka (1992, pp. 105–106) describes primary interjections through their independent utterance capacity, limited combination, and lack of productive inflection. Wilkins (1992, pp. 124–125) likewise identifies a formal profile of conventional lexical utterances, keeping their semantic and pragmatic properties available for separate investigation.

This category licenses an inference between environments. An analyst who has established the grammatical assignment of reaction *ouch* from independent uses can expect it also to supplement an intact clause. From an identified supplementary *oops*, the analyst can expect an independent utterance without recovering a missing predicate. The grammatical descriptions warrant these expectations about the core; the pairs in (1) illustrate their application. Neither the examples nor the category claim imply free combination with every clause or a measured rate of predictive success.

An isolated word can have a different analysis. Ordinary *Stop!* is an imperative clause: the verb retains the possibilities illustrated by *Stop the car!* and *Don't stop!*. A reply *Coffee* to *What would you like?* retains nominal organization, also visible in *Some coffee*. These constructed comparisons extend the contrast drawn by Wilkins (1992, pp. 124–125) with adjectival *Black* as an answer to a question about colour. Utterance status alone doesn't reclassify the word.

Supplement function is shared by several categories. Compare the interjection with the relative clause and noun phrase in these examples, adapted from *CGEL* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1356–1357, 1360).

(2) a. *Ah, so you were there after all!*
b. *We called in to see Sue's parents, which made us rather late.*
c. *A university lecturer, Dr Brown, was arrested for the crime.*

The relative clause and noun phrase retain their internal structure and other distributional possibilities. The interjection's assignment rests on the broader lexical profile. Treating all three as supplements answers a question about their relation to an anchor; distinguishing their categories answers questions about their internal organization and distribution elsewhere. The two classifications can both be correct.

The core also supports expectations beyond distribution. Its members characteristically express reactions, give voice to affective or cognitive states, or seek a listener's attention or action. A speaker can use *Ouch!* to react to pain, *Hey!* to attract attention, and *Sh!* to request silence. Ameka (1992, pp. 113–115) distinguishes expressive, conative, and phatic functions while allowing overlap. The grammatical grouping gives an initial expectation about this range of contributions; the narrower groupings specify which one.

The expectation extends to realization. Interjections characteristically form their own intonation units, including when they accompany another utterance (Ameka, 1992, p. 108). The core also admits sound patterns outside ordinary English words: *sh* can lack a vowel (Ameka, 1992, pp. 105–106), and *ugh* can contain a consonant absent from the usual standard British and American English inventories (Quirk et al., 1985, pp. 74, 853). Grammatical membership thus gives reason to anticipate separate prosodic packaging and to allow for unusual segmental realizations.

These expectations are defeasible and differ in strength. Separate intonational packaging is characteristic; unusual segmental phonology is a recurrent possibility, alongside ordinary sound patterns. The descriptions support this qualitative profile without supplying numerical probabilities. Where

the grammatical assignment has been established independently of the target property, it can guide expectations about that property. Section 4 develops the phonological and prosodic relations.

CGEL's broad characterization of interjection meaning as expressive (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1361) fits this wider profile. It leaves room for the narrower expressive grouping developed below, which concerns evaluative or affective stance. Conative *sh* can be a secure grammatical member without requiring that contribution. The category's grammatical standing and its wider inferential reach go together: distributional generalizations establish one contribution, while associations with meaning, use, and realization extend its value.[1]

2.2 Expressive commonality across a grammatical boundary

Standalone *Damn!* and supplementary *damn* in *Damn, we're going to be late!* extend the grammatical comparison to a form with an independently available verbal use. *CGEL* analyzes the exclamatory uses as reanalysed interjections (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1361). Their distribution supplies the link to the core; their conveyed stance supplies a different link to expressive uses elsewhere in the grammar.

Prenominal *damn*, in *the damn car*, occurs inside the noun phrase while contributing an attitude toward its referent. Potts (2007, pp. 171, 182) distinguishes that expressive contribution from descriptive content. Grammatical integration leaves a semantic relation to standalone *Damn!* available for analysis. The grammatical analysis separates these uses; the expressive analysis groups them together. Each preserves a relation needed for its own question.

Complement-taking *Damn these mosquitoes!* presents a further grammatical question. The phrase's external detachment is compatible with complementation inside it. *CGEL* tentatively treats the head as an exceptional interjection taking a noun-phrase complement (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, 1361 n. 70). A verbal analysis remains a substantive alternative. This disagreement concerns the head's grammar; recognizing expressive commonality with the other *damn* uses leaves it intact.

The semantic grouping here is expressive signs: conventional uses whose deployment conveys an evaluative or affective stance, rather than merely describing that stance. This intended contribution is narrower than all non-descriptive or use-conditional meaning. A conventional instruction for managing interpretation or interaction needn't express such a stance. Potts's account supplies expectations about perspective dependence, immediacy, and intensifying repetition (Potts, 2007, pp. 166–167). For *damn*, these ask whose attitude is conveyed, whether the utterance displays that attitude on the occasion of speaking, and whether repeating the form strengthens it. These semantic expectations remain available across the grammatical difference. Their extension to other expressive signs depends on the evidence for those signs and properties.

Expressive commonality extends across the grammatical boundary. Prenominal *damn* qualifies because of its conveyed stance, while the grammatical core includes conative uses for which that stance isn't required. A fuller account of expressives can include integrated signs with no traditional interjection label. Selecting examples from interjection disputes lets us compare the two groupings without adding a semantic membership condition based on that traditional label.

[1] The grammatical analysis can itself be disputed. Wilkins (1992, 126–127 n. 5) treats *oh* in *Oh, don't go on like an old fool* as a particle use, while reporting Ameka's co-utterance analysis. The core claim concerns identified conventional uses, not every occurrence of a spelling.

2.3 Expressive and depictive signs

Compare the selected expressive use of *Damn!* with a sound depiction *Bang!* in a narrative. The bearer in each case is the conventional use, not every occurrence of the spelling. The question is what contribution the use makes to interpretation. The strongest simple alternative groups both as expressive interjections on the basis of their vividness and standalone packaging. That alternative still has to explain the difference between conveying an attitude and presenting a sound.

A depictive sign conventionally presents a sound, event, or sensory scene through a resemblance between aspects of its performance and what it depicts. Dingemanse's account of ideophones supplies the wider comparison: conventional lexical items can depict sensory imagery, and their grammatical organization varies across languages (Dingemanse, 2018, pp. 2–3). The term expressive is itself used for ideophones in some traditions; that usage doesn't identify them with Potts's expressives.

For the selected *Bang!*, the relevant contribution is a portrayal of an impact sound. For *Damn!*, it's the conveyed stance toward a situation. The distinction changes the interpretation of a possible modification. In a constructed narrative, *bang, bang, bang* can multiply portrayed impacts; repeated *damn* can strengthen the conveyed stance. Repetition can thus transform the contribution in different ways. These examples articulate the contrast to be explained; they aren't results from a new elicitation study.

The literature motivates those different targets. Potts treats repetition as potentially strengthening expressive contribution (Potts, 2007, pp. 181–182). Dingemanse connects depictive performance with iconic mappings between form and scene (Dingemanse, 2018, pp. 10–11). An investigation can ask whether repetition changes portrayed event structure, conveyed stance, or both. It needn't assume one answer for every form traditionally called an interjection.

The descriptive comparison has a definite result. Separate expressive and depictive groupings preserve a difference in contribution that the undifferentiated alternative omits. A richer alternative could keep one superordinate class and record the difference as subtypes or dimensions. For this descriptive task, that's an acceptable equivalent if it retains the two relations. The result requires the distinction; it doesn't require a particular taxonomic rank.

Existing accounts can also warrant expectations about how a contribution will change. Potts's repetition generalization gives reason to expect intensification for his expressive cases; the depictive comparison asks how repeated performance maps onto the portrayed scene. The projected behavior needs to remain distinct from the assignment evidence. Identifying a use as depictive from its response to repetition and then predicting that response would recycle the same observation.

The groupings also needn't be disjoint. A depiction can convey an attitude, and an expressive performance can exploit resemblance. What matters is whether the relevant contribution is conventional in the selected use and what follows from it. Semantics can investigate both relations, or several more, without assigning each to a separate department or requiring one category to represent the semantic perspective as a whole.

2.4 Contribution, encoding, and competing analyses

Consider the constructed utterance *The damn car won't start*, said after several failed attempts at ignition. The speaker reports a starting problem and conveys a negative attitude. Calling *damn* expressive identifies that second contribution. Asking how the wording helps a hearer recover the attitude raises a different question about its encoding.

Wharton (2016) develops a procedural account of expressive meaning, connecting guidance for interpretation with the showing of emotion. Applied to the car example, such an account would treat *damn* as a cue for recognizing the attitude being shown. The use could then be expressive in contribution and procedural in encoding. Those descriptions would answer different questions about the same utterance.

Now imagine a narrator representing the car's backfire with *Bang!*. The sign depicts a noise, and its performance can resemble what it depicts. That iconic presentation differs from *damn*'s conveyed stance. Identifying the depiction still leaves open how the sign guides interpretation: resemblance alone doesn't decide whether it supplies conceptual content, an interpretive procedure, or some combination.

Two accounts would compete if they made exclusive claims about the same *damn* use. Suppose one assigned it only conceptual content, such as a negative evaluation, while the other assigned it only a procedure for recognizing an attitude. These are hypothetical rivals, not summaries of Potts and Wharton. The first needn't make annoyance part of what the sentence asserts. Their incompatible claims about encoding would require adjudication.

Finer groupings also become visible in ordinary situations. Someone touches a hot pan and says *Ouch!*; someone finds missing keys under a newspaper and says *Aha!*. The situations are constructed; Ameka (1992, p. 113) gives the forms as examples of emotive and cognitive interjections. The first gives voice to a sensation, the second displays a change in knowledge or recognition.

Ameka's mental-state grouping is broader than the stance grouping used here. Finding the keys can be displayed with *Aha!* without conventionally evaluating them. That reading motivates a cognitive subtype; it doesn't prevent another occurrence from also conveying affect. Different contributions, crosscutting accounts of encoding, and rival encoding hypotheses thus have different consequences even within this small set of expressions.

2.5 Interactional resource classes

Consider two constructed exchanges. A teller says *I tried the front door*, a listener responds *Mm-hm*, and the teller continues *but it was locked*. The listener supports continuation of the story. In a second exchange, someone says *We meet at five*; a recipient who missed the time responds *Huh?*, and the first speaker repeats *At five*. Here the response prompts repair.

The difference concerns what happens next: the story proceeds after the continuer, while the meeting time is repeated after the repair initiator. Closing *bye* has another job, participating in the end of an encounter. Accounts of interjections in conversation make these sequential differences central (Dingemanse, 2024, pp. 257–259, 263–265). Grammatical interjectionhood can orient expectations toward reactive or interaction-managing uses; these finer categories identify the particular sequential relation.

For comparison, these can be collected as conventional action formats: non-elliptical resources that can perform their action without a lexically specified host. The working class collects resources whose particular sequential consequences need separate characterization. Predictions about whether another turn continues a story or repairs an utterance belong to particular resource classes and environments. A broader grouping can remain informative at a coarser level without deciding between them.

The criterion has consequences at the boundary. Response *okay* and closing or thanking *thanks* are candidates insofar as their selected uses conventionally perform the relevant action. A formulaic

greeting *how are you?* can qualify despite having several words. An ordinary imperative *stop!* doesn't qualify merely because clause structure permits it to stand alone; a claim that it's also a conventional routine needs evidence beyond that structure.

Host-dependent *please* in *please sit down* belongs to a different comparison. A standalone appeal *Please!* would have to be assessed as that selected use. Thus the admission rule concerns conventional action formats, rather than brevity, wordhood, or every expression capable of being uttered alone. These constructed comparisons specify the proposal; they don't supply an annotated inventory.

The grammatical treatment of *mm-hm* and *huh?* likewise needs more than standalone occurrence. Ameka (1992, p. 114) includes the former among phatic interjections; Wilkins (1992, p. 152) treats repair *huh?* as a conventional utterance. For the selected uses, I adopt the non-elliptical analysis: neither needs a recovered nominal head or clause to supply its interpretation. The grammatical assignments below are defeasible analyses supported by these descriptions, rather than deductions from punctuation.

Routine formulae expose competition within an inquiry. Ameka (1992, pp. 108–110) separates *bye*, *sorry*, and *thank you* from interjections, whereas Wilkins (1992, p. 142) treats routines as a subtype. Both attend to meaning and interaction. Assigning each a disciplinary label would misdescribe their disagreement. The selected closing format can be compared with continuers without settling whether the wider grouping is the most useful category for either question.

2.6 Common bearers and distinct questions

A sign-type is an identifiable expression in a conventional use. Its profile is the combination of grammatical, semantic, interactional, and other properties attributed to it. A use can retain its identity while a proposed property turns out to be absent. Otherwise every surprising observation would identify a different object and leave the original proposal immune to correction.

The recurrent contrast between standalone and prenominal *damn* supports distinguishing their conventional uses. In the complement-taking case, Table 1 classifies the lexical head *damn* in that construction. The whole phrase's external distribution is evidence about its environment, not a replacement bearer. The table records analytical judgments, not counts or results of a new annotation study.

The table records three useful relations. The grammatical core groups uses with different contributions, including reactions and conatives. The expressive grouping connects standalone and prenominal *damn* across a grammatical difference. Within the semantic comparison, stance and depiction distinguish what the selected *Damn!* and *Bang!* contribute. A single ordering from less to more interjectional can't substitute for these inquiry-specific distinctions without losing relevant information. An ordering may still be useful for a specified task.

Bang! makes the unresolved grammatical question concrete. English also has nominal *bang*, as in the constructed *a loud bang* and *two bangs*. A standalone occurrence needs assessment against a nominal-fragment analysis. Its depictive interpretation can be recognized while that question remains open. Section 4 completes the related assessment of what phonological evidence can decide.

3 What warrants a class, a category, or an explanation?

The grammatical core supports expectations about distribution, characteristic contributions, and forms of realization. Expressive classification extends some of those expectations across a grammatical boundary; the expressive–depictive comparison distinguishes further relations within meaning.

Table 1: Selected conventional uses and the relations preserved by named analyses. The columns organize descriptions; they don't allocate one category to each field.

Selected bearer	Grammatical analysis	Meaning or action under comparison
Reaction *ouch!*; *oops!*	Core grammatical interjections	Pain or mishap reaction
Attention-getting *hey!*; silencing *sh!*	Core grammatical interjections	Conative contributions; no evaluative or affective stance required by these selected readings
gee!; stance *damn!*	Interjection	Expressive contribution; stance display
damn in *damn + NP*	Interjection head or verb: unresolved	Expressive contribution; the head's sequential affordances remain to be specified
Prenominal *damn*	Integrated modifier	Expressive contribution across a grammatical difference
Continuer *mm-hm*	Interjection analysis adopted	Continuation resource; no evaluative stance required by the selected reading
Repair *huh?*	Interjection analysis adopted	Open repair initiator; no evaluative stance required by the selected reading
Closing *bye*	Formulaic standalone expression	Closing resource
Depictive *Bang!*	Interjection or nominal-fragment analysis: unresolved	Sound depiction; stance is a separate question

Each grouping can supply information relevant to another inquiry. Assessing the particular inferences explains both their usefulness and their limits: the groupings overlap without becoming interchangeable, and reliable associations still leave their causal explanation open.

3.1 Bearers, grouping, contribution, and alternatives

Four questions organize the assessment. What bears membership? What groups the members? What does the grouping help an investigator distinguish, infer, or explain? And what alternative would serve the same inquiry? Each proposal also needs a scope: a language or community, relevant conditions, and, where the claim concerns change, a period. These questions apply to established proposals and new candidates alike.

The BEARER is the object grouped. Two recordings of *The damn car won't start* contain two realizations of the selected prenominal *damn* use. Counting the recordings gives two occurrences, not two sign-types. A phonologist can classify the individual productions; a lexical inquiry can ask about the conventional use they realize. A historian may instead classify a change connecting an earlier sign with a later one.

The GROUPING BASIS supplies the assignment evidence. Prenominal *damn* enters the expressive grouping because of its conveyed stance, while its position inside *the damn car* supplies grammatical evidence. Grouping it with standalone *Damn!* for the first reason doesn't erase their difference in the second respect. Other proposals can use ancestry or participation in a social repertoire; each needs to identify the relation its membership records.

The grouping basis doesn't set a disciplinary boundary around the contribution. Grammatical evidence can identify an interjection whose prosodic realization is still unknown. The category's established profile then supports an expectation about its packaging. Conversely, expressive contribution can motivate a comparison between grammatically different *damn* uses. The source of an assignment and the target of an inference needn't belong to the same domain.

The CONTRIBUTION identifies what the grouping accomplishes. A constructed class can fix a comparison set. A descriptive class can organize a recurrent relation across independently identified cases. A category claim requires evidence that co-occurring properties support induction beyond the application conditions. A causal claim requires evidence about the process producing an outcome. These achievements can accumulate, but evidence for an earlier one doesn't establish a later one automatically.

Descriptive success can be assessed without requiring a prediction about a differently named property. The expressive grouping preserves a semantic relation across standalone and integrated constructions; the expressive–depictive contrast records different contributions concealed by the broad cover term. Those descriptive achievements establish which similarities an adequate account needs to preserve. Further projections can build on them, with their warrant assessed against the evidence for the particular expectation.

An ALTERNATIVE can be a broader class, narrower subtypes, a continuous dimension, or an item-by-item account. In the worked semantic comparison, separate classes and a superordinate class with explicit subtypes both preserve the decisive distinction. For an inquiry into recipient responses, action-specific groupings may be more informative than their union. The number and rank of categories are outcomes of comparison, rather than requirements supplied by a field or inquiry.

Table 2: Assessing the expressive grouping without conflating its achievements

Question	Proposed answer	Evidential consequence
Bearer	Conventional uses, including standalone and prenominal *damn*	Identify each use without requiring the target property under investigation.
Grouping	Deployment conventionally conveys evaluative or affective stance	Distinguish this from describing an emotion, depicting a scene, or managing interaction.
Contribution	Preserve expressive commonality across grammatical constructions	Distinguish the observed contrast from its extension to new realizations, environments, or sign-types.
Alternative	An undifferentiated interjection class, explicit subtypes, or item-specific accounts	Compare which semantic relations each preserves and what further generalization each warrants.

3.2 From proposal to category claim

An admission rule fixes which cases enter a class. A category claim makes a further commitment: membership supports informative expectations beyond the evidence used to assign it. Assembling a grouping and warranting those expectations can succeed or fail separately. Here, category standing names the latter achievement; it isn't a verdict on whether a descriptive class is scientifically useful.

Three constructed comparisons distinguish the reach of an expectation. After identifying the expressive contribution in *The damn car won't start*, an investigator could examine another speaker's utterance of that sentence, the question *Has the damn car broken down?*, or *The bloody car won't start*. These comparisons change the realization, the environment, and the expression respectively.

The question supplies a concrete target: does the negative stance remain conveyed while the car's breakdown is put in question? Evidence from declaratives needn't settle that. The investigator can test the familiar property in a new environment without inventing a differently named property. Generalizing to independently identified *bloody* makes a further commitment across sign-types. Neither move is licensed simply by defining the class to contain the desired cases.

An additional shared property isn't sufficient merely because it's additional. If all members and nearly every sign outside a proposed grouping exhibit the target repetition behavior, membership supplies little additional guidance about it. An imperfect probabilistic association can be informative when it changes a warranted expectation at the stated scope. The alternatives in the preceding section help assess that contribution.

This comparison concerns what membership licenses an investigator to expect. Whether a category representation improves a particular model is a separate question, taken up below. Projective warrant doesn't require that representation to outperform every account of the same evidence. Both claims remain limited to the profile and scope supported: support for a subtype doesn't automatically extend to its superordinate class.

For the grammatical core in Section 2.1, the reach includes both use across constructions and associations with meaning and realization. The grammatical descriptions warrant the distributional connection; descriptions of meaning and prosody support the wider profile. A category earns gram-

matical standing through grammatical generalizations, but the information available from membership can extend well beyond them.

The source evidence matters for each inference. An assignment established from distribution can support an expectation about an unexamined intonation boundary. If that boundary helped identify the case, predicting it adds nothing; characteristic packaging can instead be assessed in another realization. This distinction concerns what was observed and what's projected, rather than which field owns either property.

I also adopt the action-specific categories for the sequential relations documented in the cited descriptions. The same evidential policy applies across inquiries: established descriptions can warrant scoped semantic and interactional projections without a new experiment in this paper.

The semantic comparisons trace expressive commonality across grammatical distinctions and distinguish stance from depiction. Potts's account also supplies expectations about the behavior of expressives, including their intensification under repetition. Those expectations remain available for integrated uses such as prenominal *damn*. The grammatical and expressive classifications each reach beyond a description of their membership, while differing in which uses and properties they connect.

3.3 Projection and identity

Revising the analysis of a conventional use can improve subsequent predictions without turning an earlier failure into a success. To keep those judgments separate, a projective claim states what's been observed, what's expected, and over which bearers and conditions. Its WARRANT is the evidence supporting that expectation (Goodman, 1955). Claim content, evidential status, and proposed causal ground can then be assessed separately (Reynolds, 2026, pp. 11–12).

Suppose source contexts identify an expressive use and the target is its interpretation under repetition. Repetition can't also supply the case-level evidence used to admit that use. Similarly, if resistance to determiner combination is the target, an unexpected determiner can't by itself justify excluding the case as conversion. A change to the identification rule creates a revised claim requiring assessment.

Imagine an investigator who's identified expressive *damn* only in standalone reactions such as *Damn! We've missed the train*. Their provisional identification uses the reaction meaning; it doesn't require standalone position. They predict that these uses resist grammatical integration. Encountering *The damn car won't start* then presents an adverse case: the expression conveys stance while functioning as an integrated modifier inside the noun phrase.

This is a hypothetical research sequence using familiar constructions. The investigator should check the structural analysis, but the confirmed prenominal occurrence counts against the restriction under the original identification rule. Its inconvenient distribution isn't by itself a reason to remove it from that assessment. Later recognizing a distinct prenominal use can improve the analysis without making the original prediction successful.

Evaluate the original projection under the identification rule available when it was made. Later evidence may warrant distinguishing a recurrent conventional use by its contribution or distribution. That revision can improve subsequent predictions, but it doesn't remove earlier counterexamples from the original assessment. Observations that motivate a new distinction don't also supply independent confirmation of its predictive success.

A quoted token or a productive noun denoting an utterance remains another possible analysis, but it needs evidence for quotation or nominal reference. A correction to a mistaken structural ana-

lysis should be recorded as such. It differs from changing the identification rule so that a confirmed counterexample no longer falls within its scope.

An informative restriction also needs relevant opportunities. Failure to observe inflection says little if the sampled environments wouldn't elicit it under a rival analysis. Testing distribution requires relevant constructions; testing a sequential expectation requires the relevant interactional environments. Either prediction can start from evidence of membership in a category established for another inquiry. The common bearer connects those claims to the same use while preserving the evidence needed to assess each one.

3.4 Representation and causal explanation

Suppose an inventory records that a use occurs standalone and conveys stance. Adding the label "standalone stance use" abbreviates those two observations; it adds no information to a fully observed record. The combined grouping could still be useful when investigating something not yet recorded, such as interpretation under repetition. Pooling observations from its members might help estimate that pattern from sparse records. Whether it does is a comparative question.

The grouping selects an intersection: stance *Damn!* qualifies, while prenominal *damn* in *the damn car* fails the standalone condition. A model can represent that intersection as one label or keep its two component assignments. Their relative value depends on the information available and the target being predicted. A benefit for estimating repetition behavior wouldn't establish a unique cause of the shared properties or priority for every inquiry.

Explanation asks another question. Once the present form of *gee* has been recorded, knowing its religious source adds nothing to that already observed spelling. Its history can still explain how the form arose. More generally, conditioning a prediction on consequences of a historical process can remove the association through which that process is recognized. Section 5 distinguishes this predictive comparison from assessment of the proposed history itself.

Hill (1965, pp. 295–299) offered viewpoints for comparing causal interpretations with alternatives, including temporal order and consistency with independently supported knowledge. These concern specified causes and outcomes. In the history of *gee*, for example, the sequence of semantic change and clipping helps distinguish the processes that contributed to the present form (Section 5).

4 Phonological organization and situated realization

Grammatical interjectionhood is informative about sound as well as distribution. Its characteristic profile includes separate intonational packaging and an openness to sounds or combinations unusual elsewhere in a variety. A phonological inquiry can pursue those associations and also group signs across grammatical categories. Even where the grammatical analysis of depictive *Bang!* remains unsettled, its phonological realization is available for comparison.

These observations motivate different classifications. The first can group sign-types by their phonological possibilities. The second groups realizations by how speakers produce them in context. Their relation connects the resources available for a conventional sign with the ways speakers realize it on particular occasions.

4.1 A phonological stratum of signs

English conversational clicks make the first possibility concrete. The click represented by *tut-tut* differs from an ordinary spelling pronunciation (Wilkins, 1992, p. 147). Forms such as *ugh* permit

sounds outside the usual phoneme inventory of standard British and American English (Quirk et al., 1985, pp. 74, 853). A phonological inquiry can ask which conventional signs admit such resources, how their variants are organized, and how speakers acquire or adapt them.

These possibilities contribute to the interjection profile. Having identified a grammatical interjection, an investigator has reason to consider a wider range of conventional sound patterns than the ordinary word phonology would allow (Ameka, 1992, pp. 105–106). Some members use that range and others have ordinary phonology. Membership guides expectations without predicting an anomalous segment in every item.

Ameka (1992, pp. 112–113) diagnoses a different inference: unusual phonology shared with interjections has been used to include onomatopoeic words in the grammatical interjection category. His alternative recognizes a phonological grouping whose members can belong to different grammatical categories. The forward association and this objection are compatible: grammatical membership can inform phonological expectations without unusual phonology being sufficient for grammatical membership.

The grammatical claim concerns membership in a lexical category. The evidence offered concerns sounds or sound patterns unusual elsewhere in the language. That evidence supports a comparison of phonological possibilities across independently identified signs. By itself, it doesn't settle whether a particular use has nominal, verbal, or interjectional grammar. Nor does sound depiction itself entail phonological anomaly: resemblance and distribution within the sound system are different relations.

The reverse inference can also have value as defeasible evidence. Its strength depends on how the observed phonological property is distributed among competing grammatical analyses. Evidence that interjections permit unusual sounds doesn't by itself settle how diagnostic an unusual sound is of interjectionhood. That question concerns the association and its alternatives, rather than a prohibition on inference across domains.

For English *Bang!*, the competing grammatical analysis is a standalone nominal fragment, supported as a possibility by the independently available noun in *a loud bang*. A depictive interpretation leaves that analysis open. Even if an occurrence had unusual phonation, the additional observation would concern its realization. Choosing between nominal and interjectional analyses needs distributional and constructional evidence about the selected conventional use, or an independently warranted association connecting the observed phonology to that grammar.

The strongest alternative retains one broad descriptive class and records phonology and grammar as separate attributes. For organizing known cases, that can preserve the same information. It becomes inadequate only if membership in the broad class is used to infer a grammatical assignment without the relevant evidence. The assessment rejects that sufficient test while retaining both the wider interjection profile and the cross-grammatical phonological comparison. Establishing one projectible phonological stratum would require its own family of supported expectations.

An account of the stratum would gain projective reach if membership organized acquisition, adaptation, or alternation beyond the diagnostic used to identify it. Consider the contrast between producing a click and pronouncing *tut-tut* as spelled words. An investigation could first group signs by independently recorded articulations, then ask which permit a spelling pronunciation and in what settings. That prospective comparison would test a relation beyond the articulation used for grouping; the reported alternatives don't yet establish it.

Regular phonology matters too. In a ten-language study of open repair interjections, Dinge-

manse et al. (2013) find broad phonetic similarities alongside language-specific vowel targets and intonation. The repair interjections in Icelandic and Cha'palaa have falling contours, consistent with local interrogative prosody. The study concerns comparable repair environments. It supplies no reason to assign every occurrence resembling *huh* to one phonologically exceptional class.

Phonological classification thus has work to do within ordinary linguistic organization as well as at its margins. An inquiry into repair intonation could group forms with interrogative resources; another into unusual segments could group conversational clicks with other marked forms. Both could be useful. A single label such as PHONOLOGICAL INTERJECTION would obscure the difference unless the inquiry and grouping basis were specified.

4.2 Prosodic classes of realizations

A prosodic boundary is a property of a realization, and a sign-type's characteristic packaging supports expectations about its realizations. For an independently identified interjection, separate intonational phrasing is a reasonable default (Ameka, 1992, p. 108), with variation across environments. Realizations of grammatically different signs can share a boundary pattern. Supplements provide a familiar example: interjections, noun phrases, and relative clauses can all be prosodically detached (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 66, 1350).

Take a recording of *Damn, we're going to be late!*. The context can identify the reaction use while the acoustic record supplies evidence about a boundary, such as a pause or pitch movement. A second recording can realize the same use with different timing. The category supplies an expectation before each boundary is measured; the recordings show whether and how it's realized. Estimating the strength of that tendency requires productions across relevant environments.

Interaction supplies some of those environments. Ogden (2013) describes English clicks and percussives in stance-taking, sequence management, word searches, and turn timing, with visual behaviour contributing to their interpretation. A classification of productions by timing and articulation can intersect an analysis of sequential practices. The range of jobs also cautions against assigning one conventional action or expressive meaning to every click.

The comma in a transcript of *Damn, we're going to be late!* is a different kind of observation. It may record a transcriber's analysis of detachment, but it isn't itself a pause or a grammatical relation. Entering that comma once as a prosodic boundary and again as syntactic independence would manufacture apparent agreement between the measures. An acoustic analysis and a constructional analysis can converge without relying on that single transcription decision.

The two phonological inquiries extend the family in different ways. Phonological strata can share their sign-type bearers and enter membership intersections. Prosodic classes of occurrences connect to them through realization and through distributions over contexts. A sign-type table can record a propensity for separate intonational packaging. Keeping that propensity distinct from each realized boundary lets the table support a prediction whose outcome can be checked.

5 Historical ancestry and classes of change

The history of *gee* explains a feature of its present form that a synchronic interjection label leaves unexplained. Signs with different current distributions can descend from related sources, while signs with similar current profiles can arrive by different routes.

A historical inquiry can classify present signs by independently established ancestry. It can also classify changes, such as clipping or reanalysis. The first has sign-types as bearers; the second has

changes linking sources and outcomes.

5.1 The documented route to *gee*

Gehweiler (2008) traces *gee* through an invocation of *Jesus*, an exclamatory use of the religious name, and a clipped form. In the invocation, the speaker addresses the deity. The exclamation can express a reaction without that address. Clipping then produces a form whose relation to the name can become opaque. The sequence separates semantic change from the later change of form.

The transitions also have different proposed explanations. Gehweiler relates the first to gradual invited inference, aided by the syntactically peripheral invocation. She analyzes the clipping as an abrupt, taboo-motivated change involving hearer reanalysis (Gehweiler, 2008, pp. 84–88). The source invocation already permits peripheral packaging.

The history explains why the shape of *gee* bears a relation to religious invocation even for a speaker who doesn't recognize that relation. Its present opacity alone wouldn't identify its ancestry. The documented sequence supplies the additional evidence for a restricted instance of path dependence: a particular route helps explain a feature of its outcome, without making every other outcome of that route predictable.

The explanation concerns a particular outcome. It doesn't yet establish that a class of signs with religious ancestry outperforms alternatives or supports a common projection. That comparison would require independently documented histories and outcomes across more than this one route.

The distinction also corrects an ambiguity in primary and secondary interjections. Ameka's distinction concerns whether a form has other, non-interjectional uses in the language (Ameka, 1992, pp. 105–106). It isn't a partition into historically underived and historically derived signs. Gehweiler's primary *gee* has a documented derived history. Conversely, an unknown etymology supplies a gap in knowledge, not a common origin shared by all forms whose sources remain unknown.

5.2 Source, mechanism, transmission, and trajectory

A useful historical description separates four relations. The source identifies an earlier sign or construction. The mechanism specifies a change, such as clipping or reanalysis. The transmission setting concerns how the innovation spreads, including borrowing where supported. The subsequent trajectory concerns further changes in use or form. Signs can share one relation without sharing the other three.

For *gee*, a religious invocation supplies the source and tabooistic clipping supplies one mechanism. Those facts don't establish the transmission history of every later community's use. Nor does a shared source force a common trajectory: an exclamatory religious name can remain phonologically close to its source without later undergoing clipping. Historical classes can be organized at several levels, according to which relation the inquiry needs.

The proposed verbal route to complement-taking *damn* illustrates unequal support among histories. *God damn him* has the shape of an optative, a construction independently recognized in English (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 944). Omission of the subject and increasing conventional expressive force offer a plausible route to *damn him*. The surviving complement fits that reconstruction. These synchronic comparisons don't establish the sequence as independently as Gehweiler's historical record does.

The source optative already uses plain-form *damn*, so the reconstruction doesn't require loss of tense marking at that transition. And the present complement remains compatible with competing

analyses of the head as verbal or interjectional. A classification by independently established verbal ancestry could cross that present grammatical boundary. Inferring the ancestry solely from the complement and then invoking the ancestry to predict that same complement would be circular.

Classes of changes require a different representation. An instance of clipping relates an earlier form to an outcome; an instance of semantic reanalysis relates earlier and later interpretations. Neither is itself a sign-type alongside *gee* and *damn*. A process classification can support comparisons among developments, while explicit source–result relations connect those developments to classifications of their inputs and outputs.

5.3 What historical evidence can establish

Historical explanation and forward projection need different comparisons. A documented route may explain a present feature through the changes that produced it. A forward projection asks what information about the route warrants expecting in another case. For a verbal-source class, that target could concern surviving restrictions on dependents, provided those restrictions weren't used to assign the source. The present examples motivate that inquiry without establishing a category-wide result.

Evidence for replication also needs to distinguish innovations from their descendants. Suppose one community coins a clipped exclamation and three others borrow it. Four community records then document one origin, not four independent instances of clipping. They can support an account of transmission or subsequent divergence. Testing whether the same source repeatedly gives rise to the same outcome would require independently established innovations. This hypothetical count makes the sampling unit depend on the historical claim.

An ancestry classification can still explain a present contrast even when ancestry adds no predictive information after all its consequences are observed. Conditioning on those consequences changes the question to whether ancestry contributes anything further. That can be a useful test of predictive economy; it isn't a general test of whether the documented process occurred or helped produce the contrast.

Historical classes can have two kinds of payoff. They can organize independently supported source relations among present signs, and they can compare processes across developments. These are legitimate descriptive and explanatory contributions. An empirical ancestry category, in the stronger usage adopted here, also needs support for the inductions it licenses. The documented history of one sign can't supply that support for an entire source class.

6 Broader classes and further inquiries

The traditional interjection domain also intersects classes whose most informative members lie elsewhere. Social evaluation can group forms by their appropriateness for audiences and settings. Processing inquiries can group familiar expressions by how they're produced or understood. An interjection's membership in either class needn't make the class interjection-specific. Three questions remain distinct: whether the broader class is supported, how it intersects the traditional domain, and whether an INTERJECTION label helps describe that intersection.

6.1 Social evaluation and recognized repertoires

Religious exclamations connect the historical case to a further classification. In Gehweiler's account, taboo pressure contributes to clipping *Jesus* into *gee*. A present-day inquiry can group uses by their

evaluated appropriateness for an audience or setting. It asks how speakers assess the available forms in their own community.

Jay and Janschewitz (2008) examine ratings of hypothetical swearing scenarios, finding that judgments depend on the word, speaker–listener relations, and social and physical context. These ratings support contextual differentiation in evaluations of taboo language.

Consider a proposed comparison of *Gee!* and *Jesus!* as reactions to surprising news among close friends and during a formal interview. Ratings would ask how appropriate each choice seems in each setting. A difference in those ratings would distinguish social appropriateness without by itself changing the grammatical classification of the reaction.

Social indexing poses a related but distinct inquiry. Agha's account of enregisterment concerns the social recognition of speech forms as indexing attributes of speakers, with a repertoire's associations and social reach subject to change (Agha, 2005, pp. 38–40). A classification by participation in a recognized repertoire could cross grammatical, semantic, and sequential divisions. The relevant evidence concerns recognition and use of those associations, beyond a frequency difference between geographical collections.

For example, if listeners regularly associated *Gee!* with an old-fashioned speaker persona, their judgments would support a social association. They wouldn't merely be rating whether it was acceptable in the interview. Both investigations could concern the same surprise reaction, while asking different questions about its social meaning. Such associations could also unite forms used for several actions. Any claimed convention would need a specified community and evidence of shared recognition.

6.2 Formulaicity and processing

Compare a familiar greeting, *How are you?*, a pause filler, *um*, and the idiom *kick the bucket*. These illustrative forms differ in grammar and conversational job. A processing inquiry could ask whether speakers produce them as familiar routines. Its grouping would cross the earlier grammatical and semantic divisions; formulaic expressions might name it more clearly than another kind of interjection.

Van Lancker Sidtis et al. (2015) report differences in formulaic language production and comprehension across clinical groups and healthy participants. Their production analysis combines six kinds of formulaic material, including conversational formulae, pause fillers, sentence stems, and idioms. The results give empirical consequences to a grouping that crosses grammatical categories: pause fillers can be studied alongside phrases and idioms despite their grammatical differences.

For the greeting, one question is whether *How are you?* is retrieved fluently because repeated use has helped establish a routine. A comparison at the same measured frequency asks how fluency differs among expressions with comparable recorded use. That adjustment doesn't by itself identify how much repetition contributed to the greeting's fluency. A causal interpretation still needs assumptions about exposure, retrieval, and how the frequency measure relates to speakers' experience.

Suppose retrieval across *How are you?*, *um*, and *kick the bucket* tracked familiarity more closely than any interjection grouping. That result would favour the broader or continuous representation for this processing inquiry. It wouldn't give the filler *um* the internal grammar of *kick the bucket*. The grammatical contrast would remain available for a different question, provided its own evidence held.

6.3 Further inquiries and their objects

Morphological analysis can distinguish a retained plural shape in exclamatory *heavens!* from a productive number contrast. Attested noun and verb uses of *ouch* in child-directed speech likewise make the conventional use consequential for grammatical classification (Stange, 2016, p. 36). The lexical profile of a reaction doesn't describe every construction containing the same spelling.

Other inquiries change the object under investigation. A child's acquisition of *ouch* concerns a learner and a series of learning episodes. A recording of *Bye!* with a wave includes visible timing absent from a lexical inventory. In a constructed comic panel, *BANG* can depict a noise without representing anyone's speech. Learning, multimodal performance, and graphic depiction connect to conventional signs through different relations, each requiring its own comparison.

Annotation supplies a practical example. A tag can retrieve conversational responses while combining several grammatical or semantic classes. Its success concerns retrieval under a coding policy. To use the retrieved tokens as evidence about a lexical category, an investigator needs to establish how that policy relates to grammatical membership. The following measurement case shows the consequence of leaving that relation unchecked.

7 A measurement case: tags, strings, and uses

A retrieval class can be useful for a corpus query and still give a misleading picture when treated as a linguistic category. In the Corpus of Global Web-Based English (GloWbE), which contains country-labelled web sections (Davies & Fuchs, 2015), the spelling *ha* retrieves both reactions and abbreviations for hectares. A tag, a string, and a conventional use select different sets. The distinction changes the apparent geographical pattern.

The constructed strings *12 ha of land* and *Ha! I knew it* make the difference visible. A search for the spelling *ha*, ignoring capitalization, can retrieve both. An investigation of the reaction use needs to distinguish them. A tag intended to make that distinction is still a measurement decision whose accuracy needs checking.

The *ha* record makes the consequence concrete. Some tagged occurrences abbreviate HECTARE, especially in agricultural prose. A rule-based screen of exported contexts changes Kenya's rank from fifth to fifteenth or sixteenth under six treatments of laughter and unclear cases; pooling gives ranks from fourteenth to sixteenth. The large movement is stable across those choices. Its exact size remains conditional on the screen and on the exported samples.

The screen was tuned against forty Kenyan and Tanzanian examples; its resulting 39/40 binary agreement is a development check. It doesn't establish equivalent accuracy in every country section. The observed geographic distribution depends on both the linguistic phenomenon and the measurement procedure. An analysis of category variation would need independently identified uses and comparable opportunities for their occurrence.

Similarly, changing frequency ranks in the Corpus of Historical American English (COHA) describe a tagged inventory (Davies, 2010). They don't establish persistence of a semantic or grammatical profile. Two further analyses, of derivatives and *fie*, fail their intended confirmatory interpretation: the primary derivative pipeline assigned semantic residue rather than measuring it, and the *fie* input retained ineligible optical character recognition substitutions. Their confirmatory claims are withdrawn.

The evidence supplement preserves the complete records: GloWbE measurement and model

comparisons (Section A), the derivative audit (Section B), the *fie* audit (Section C), and inventory turnover (Section D). Its retained model comparison predicts an omitted country–item cell within the observed design; it doesn't assess new countries, new items, or the proposed linguistic groupings. These records locate the failure at the relevant claim. A useful retrieval class survives as a tool, but its output can't establish a linguistic category without evidence connecting that class to independently identified uses.

8 The general consequence

Grammatical interjectionhood gives access to a wider profile: characteristic meanings and uses, a tendency toward separate intonational packaging, and possibilities for unusual phonology. These expectations extend the category's value beyond the grammatical generalizations that establish its standing. A classification can be informative across several inquiries even when its members vary in the associated properties.

That variation leaves other groupings useful. Conative *sh* shares the grammatical profile of *ouch* without requiring its affective contribution. Prenominal *damn* shares expressive properties with standalone *Damn!* without becoming an intermediate grammatical interjection. The relevant relations are partly aligned: grammatical membership guides expectations about meaning, while expressive classification connects uses across its boundary. Their divergence preserves information that either grouping alone would lose.

Depictive *Bang!* introduces a further semantic relation, and continuers and repair initiators organize different sequential environments. These distinctions prevent pluralism from becoming a fixed arrangement with one category for grammar, another for semantics, and a third for interaction. The number and extension of the groupings depend on the questions and the relations supported by the evidence.

8.1 Many-to-many relations and local failure

Dupré's pluralism and Khalidi's crosscutting kinds make room for multiple defensible groupings. The linguistic cases add a practical requirement: specify which relation a proposed grouping preserves and which objects participate in it. Haspelmath's division between descriptive categories and comparative concepts supplies a related lesson about analytical purpose. Here, the same care is needed within a language and within an inquiry.

In *The damn car won't start*, expressive contribution concerns the attitude conveyed; procedural encoding concerns how the wording guides its recognition. Both descriptions could hold. The contrast with depictive *Bang!* concerns a different contribution, while the exclusive encoding hypotheses in Section 2.4 disagree about the same use. Assigning the hypotheses to different fields wouldn't make their claims compatible.

Failure has correspondingly local consequences. Suppose a repetition test found that an independently identified expressive use didn't strengthen stance under the specified conditions. The prediction of intensification would fail there; the observed distinction between conveying stance and depicting a sound wouldn't disappear with it. Restricting the prediction to another subtype would create a new claim. Its support couldn't be inherited from the failed generalization.

The classifications are mutually informative without being interchangeable. Knowing that a use is a grammatical interjection gives reason to expect parts of the wider profile. Knowing that it's expressive supports more specific expectations about stance, including in integrated uses outside the

grammatical category. A phonological grouping can connect realizations that those classifications separate. Their value lies both in the associations that let one guide another and in the differences that keep one from replacing another.

8.2 Overlap, mechanisms, and category standing

Selecting standalone stance uses includes expressive *Damn!* and excludes prenominal *damn* in *the damn car*. That intersection is well-defined and can fix a useful comparison set. Its further value depends on the question: does restricting attention to those uses help with the proposed inference? Neither the overlap itself nor the availability of its component assignments answers that.

Distinct categories needn't be statistically independent, and they can share causal processes. A partial association can make membership in one informative about properties studied through another. Such associations are part of what makes the classifications useful. Strong correlation still leaves distinct questions and extensions; a shared history can help explain their alignment without establishing every present property.

For *Bang!*, uncertainty between a nominal-fragment and an interjection analysis doesn't itself establish graded membership. The analysis may simply be unresolved. A separate inquiry could ask how typical speakers judge it compared with *Damn!*; prototype accounts organize such typicality and similarity (Rosch, 1975; Taylor, 2003). Either a graded or a categorical representation can serve a task, but its form alone doesn't establish what it licenses an investigator to infer.

A field supplies no fixed quota of categories, and an inquiry needn't end with just one. A grouping may serve several questions across fields, but warrant only specified projections under specified conditions. The historical label INTERJECTION identifies a meeting point for these inquiries. The evidence, rather than the label or departmental boundary, determines which proposed categories deserve recognition.

9 Conclusion

English interjections support several classifications because the relevant properties recur in partially aligned patterns. A grammatical core including *ouch*, *oops*, *hey*, and *sh* supports expectations about independent utterance and clausal supplementation, and also about characteristic contributions and realization. Identifying a grammatical interjection gives reason to expect a reactive, expressive, or conative use, often with its own intonational packaging and with possibilities for unusual phonology. Grammatical standing doesn't confine the category's inferential reach to grammar.

Crosscutting classifications needn't be rival approximations to a single complete classification. They can be mutually informative while preserving different relations. Expressive classification connects standalone and prenominal *damn* across their grammatical difference; conative *sh* shares the grammatical core without requiring evaluative stance. The distinction between stance and depiction adds another useful semantic comparison. An apparent anomaly can thus reveal the limits of an association without undermining either category.

The same approach distinguishes coexistence from competition. Expressive commonality leaves the rival grammatical analyses of complement-taking *damn* unresolved; it doesn't reconcile them. The relevant question is what each assignment warrants expecting about the identified use, and where another classification improves or changes that expectation. Inquiry-relative categories organize overlapping routes of inference through the same linguistic material. Their reach depends on the supported associations, rather than on the disciplinary origin of the classification.

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